

Cheapest Trumpet

The Internet can be an inexpensive way to advertise your business. Find out how!

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Advertising your business used to be a costly affair; now, however, if you have a small business and want to advertise it without spending too much, there is a range of methods by which you can effectively reach your target audience—thanks to the Internet. Read on: we'll show you the best ways to build your brand on the Internet, with just a yearly kitty of a lakh!

Search Engine Marketing

Before you do anything, get your Web site up and running (domain names for your site can be bought for as little as Rs 500 a year). If it's pretty and professional-looking, so much the better.

Your site can act as a brochure of services your business offers. These days, most new business is facilitated by searches conducted on search engines, predominantly Google. If you are a small business, it is hardly likely for customers to search for your company name—the industry you work in will likely be searched for. Hence search engine marketing.

It is important to create content with your target audience in mind in order to make their experience of visiting your site relevant and useful. It is also essential to have your Web site built by a professional who will optimise it so that your name appears among the top search results for a search query relating to your industry. Search Engine Marketing (SEM) comprises two methods: Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) and Pay-Per-Click (PPC) Marketing. We've mentioned SEO in *The Future of Search* (August 2005) and *The First Page* (November 2005). PPC refers to paid search results that appear at the top and in the right-hand columns on Google, Yahoo!, and Live Search when most searches are conducted.

The SEM strategy for your Web site could revolve around the following factors:

☐ Time frame: Since SEO relies on the Web site first being indexed by the search engines, it takes longer to start working for you than does PPC. Search engine “spiders” need to index the changes to your site made by the SEO before you see improvement in your site ranking. If a business owner wants to see his site ranking higher in search results over a longer period, SEO is the way to go. However, if you need to market for a specific occasion, like selling fireworks during the *Diwali* season, and plan to advertise this in September, PPC marketing would work better—it can be implemented in a very short span of time. PPC means you bid for an ad spot and you pay the search engine each time someone clicks on your listing. You could end up paying Rs 1,500 a month (our estimate for this example) by “targeting” four keywords. (To explain the idea a little, you could target the keywords “[your city]”, “fireworks”, “crackers”, and “discount”. When any of these keywords are searched for, your ad will appear in the search engine).

☐ Keywords being targeted: It is difficult for a business with a new Web site to rank high for very generic keywords like “laptop” or “car”. Here you need to take a call on the geographical area you want to do business in, and then work on specific keywords, keeping budget in mind. Again, it is possible to target a specific city using PPC by using the city name as a keyword, which is not possible with SEO.



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